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Guardian Weekend spooler 246x292mm trim size

tracer rounds, orange sparks?), whatever it was, it shone off his face and left it luminous, like reflected light from a movie screen.

I began to grow bold around Mrs Cameron. Though I didn't dare shout at her or order her around as Tim did, I often ran past her without answering when she spoke to me, and — following Tim's lead — no longer bothered with thank you or please. If I'd behaved so badly at my own house, I would have got a spanking — but somehow I understood that Mrs Cameron wasn't going to tell. When Tim and I burst thundering into the house, with mud and leaves in our hair and dirty knees from crawling on the ground, she often looked up at us with a bright, slightly alarmed smile, all long teeth and pink gums, as if we were a pair of snappy terriers who might bite. We gulped down her lemonade without a word, snatched away the oatmeal cookies she offered us and stuffed them into our pockets and ran back out to the field again.

Then one day we galloped into the kitchen, hot and dirty, and there — at the table with Mrs Cameron, glancing up at us with a quick, flinching movement — was Tim's mother. She was young and very thin, with pale lipstick and a nervous mouth. Her collarbones stood out at the neckline of her sleeveless top; her hair was teased stiff, and back-combed; and her eyes (heavily done, with lots of dark make-up) had a bruised and slightly pleading look. She was the kind of mother that made you want to jump at her from behind a door and yell BOO.

I stopped. "Hello," I said, for I still hadn't quite forgotten my manners.

Tim's mother looked over at me and smiled, with a sort of grateful surprise; and something about the smile made me angry. It was a comradely, confidential smile, as if she assumed that I was her ally and not Tim's.

"Hiya, cutie," she said. "You're a little doll, aren't ya?" Her voice was warm and rough and startling, entirely at odds with her frail-looking person. I'd never heard a Brooklyn accent before, except on The Honeymooners or The Jackie Gleason Show.

"What's wrong, doll? Cat gotcha tongue? Listen up, buddy," she said to Tim, "what's with all the screaming and yellin' out there?"

"Oh, Gali!" said Mrs Cameron. "Let him play! He's just a little boy!" But as she reached around and drew Tim close to her I noticed — with surprise — that her eyes were pink, that she was blinking back the tears.

Tim shrugged away from her and turned to me with an expression that meant: *let's go*. And out we ran from the kitchen, clattering down the back steps, running faster than usual because we were both embarrassed by the scene (though I doubt either of us could have said quite why) and because we wanted to get back down to our palmy little Vietnam where our ambush awaited.

"Wonder what Mrs Cameron thought," my father said at dinner a few nights later, "when Bobby Cameron come back from up north married to a Jewish girl?"

I started to ask what Jewish meant, but before I could, my mother gave me a quick glance and said: "Well, I expect Mrs Cameron's glad enough to have her now that Bobby's dead."

My father reached for the salt. "Roger Bell over at the barber shop?" he said pleasantly. "He was in for a root canal the other day and *he* said she used to sell newspapers and magazines from a stand on the street. That's how Bobby met her."

"What's wrong with selling newspapers?" I said.

"Nothing," said my mother. "There's nothing wrong with working for a living."

"I'm just *saying*," busily, my father shook salt over his food. "You know it's got to kill Mrs Cameron. If Bobby had stayed home and married Kitty Teasdale, I can tell you Ogden Teasdale would have kept him out of it. Ogden's in the legislature," he said, when my mother kept on looking at him like she wanted him to shut up. "He isn't going to have any son-in-law of his going off to Vietnam."

"Well," said my mother, "all I can say is, if you went to Vietnam and got killed, I sure wouldn't be taking the children and going to live with *your* mother."

My father shrugged. "You might," he said. "If you didn't have anyplace else to go."

Both my mother and my grandmother seemed vaguely troubled that Tim and his mother were living at Mrs Cameron's, but for reasons I didn't understand. Mainly they seemed bothered that Mrs Cameron hadn't given an official explanation or made a formal announcement of any sort. ("Why hasn't anybody met her yet?" I heard my mother's friend Virginia ask. "It looks like Mrs Cameron would throw a little party or something for her, doesn't it?")

Some days, Tim's mother stayed in her room and listened to the radio — baseball games, Motown hits turned up so loud that we could hear them outside. But she was also starting to spend a lot more time downstairs. She and Mrs Cameron called each other by their first names: Rose and Gali. They sat together at the kitchen table; they drank coffee and tea; they talked, mostly in voices too low to hear. ("Sure, I was poor, growing up," I heard her say to Mrs Cameron, her husky voice rising louder than usual. "But not poor poor.") They looked at magazines and cookbooks; they looked at a scrapbook which was of things Tim's father had done in high school. Once or twice, Tim and I ran in the kitchen while Mrs Cameron was trying to teach Tim's mother how to knit, but she couldn't seem to get the hang of it ("Nah," she said, flopping her hands at the tangle of yarn, "looka this thing, I got it all screwed up. I mean, all *fouled* up," she added, when she saw the expression on Mrs Cameron's face).

By now it was full summer, and the days were almost unbearably hot. And maybe it was only the heat, but the old adrenaline punch of the game wasn't nearly so strong any more. So Tim and I played even harder, trying to pump it all up again, anything to draw fire and beat back our boredom. We tore pickets from the fence to build a stockade; we lobbed mud-clo'd grenades into the enemy stronghold; we trampled the garden in our desperate retreats, knocked over flowerpots and broke them. Sometimes Tim's mother got up from the kitchen table and came to watch us from the back porch with a strange expression on her face — but once or twice, when it looked like she was about to come out and say something, Mrs Cameron came over and took her by the arm and whispered in her ear. Then they both went inside, back to the kitchen table again.

"You see?" said Tim triumphantly, as we were carrying the "stakes" we'd torn from Mrs Cameron's cherry tree back to our position, in order to lay a trap for our enemy. "They don't mind. It's because my dad's dead."

One evening, when my grandmother came over to our house to return a book she'd borrowed, she announced: "Mrs Cameron brought that little daughter-in-law of hers to the Garden Club party yesterday."

"Oh really?" said my mother. She put down her needlework; she looked at my grandmother. "And how was that?"

"She's a pretty little thing," said my grandmother, "with a trim little figure, but my Lord! Of course she's perfectly *pleasant*."

"What do you mean?"

"It's just —" My grandmother's voice trailed away, and she made a sort of vague, meaningless gesture. We were used to these pauses of hers; she was one of those ladies who tried never to say anything about anybody if it wasn't nice.

"Well, she tries very hard indeed," she said at last, as if that was an end to it.

It took a while, but finally my mother managed to get a bit more information out of her. For one thing: Tim's mother had worn black stretch pants and spike heeled shoes; and she had also used some coarse language, though my grandmother wouldn't repeat it. Moreover, Tim had been brought to the party (my mother looked startled; this wasn't something people did) and his mother and Mrs Cameron had had a hard time controlling him.

"They won't lay a hand on him, either one of them," my grandmother said. "He ran wild all over the garden. The mother is lax, but it's not all her fault. Rose Cameron won't let her touch him."

"I wonder why?"

"Well, I don't know if you remember, but Bobby Cameron was spoiled, too." I listened uneasily as my mother and my grandmother talked about ➔

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